

Enabling Indian languages on the FOSS desktop Part 3

Your Desktop, Your Language

In the past, we've looked at how to enable word processing in your native language. In fact, your entire desktop, menus included, can be displayed in your language. This process of translation is called localisation. Find out more about it.

From operating system commands to menu entries, almost every new computing term is in the English language. The age-old problem for translators is to convey the collocations, and *moods*—baggage that doesn't often translate too well. Software translators, therefore, must be particularly careful in dealing with such terms, for fear of producing awkward and stilted work, which could mar the FOSS experience. This is the paradigm within which we'll critique the Indian-language FOSS desktop and gauge its state of readiness for you, the user.

Naturally, I can only comment on the languages that I know, and I pick Hindi for this review. I installed support for the language in my Ubuntu 8.10 GNOME desktop. *Kaisa tha*, then?

Installing and activating local-language menus

Very few distributions have Indian language menus installed by default. In Ubuntu 8.10, install the feature yourself, as follows: *System menu*→*Administration*→*Language Support* (Figure 1). Now, in the window that appears, select your language, and Ubuntu will download the fonts and menu files. It's a large download! Make sure you have a fast Internet connection. This step will also install your language keymap, so that you can word-process in your language. So if you can type in your language as the earlier article in this series described, then you've already got translated menus installed. Neat, huh?

But you'll have to activate the menus. Log out. Now, in the login window, select the *Options* menu and then *Language*. Choose your language here. Log in again with your user name and password. Hey